



Achraf Hakimi (Left) & Sadio Mané (Right) with the AFCON trophy (Middle)

During the 2025 Africa Cup of Nations Final between Senegal and Morocco, the game became very controversial near the end. First, Senegal scored a goal, but the referee disallowed it, and many players felt it was unfair because he did not clearly check VAR before making the decision. Right after that, the referee gave Morocco a penalty, which made Senegal even more upset. Morocco took the penalty but missed it, so the score stayed 0–0. As a result, Senegal's players were very angry about both decisions, so they stopped playing and walked off the field for several minutes to protest. After they returned, the match continued, went to extra time, and Senegal scored the only goal to win 1–0 on the field.

However, in the following months, the CAF reviewed what happened during the game, especially the players leaving. After investigating, in March 2026, CAF decided that leaving the pitch was against the rules. Because of this, they cancelled Senegal's win and gave Morocco a 3–0 victory, making the Morocco team the official champions. Since then there has been a fury on social media, with fans feeling upset. As stated by the *buisnessday* article, "My mum told me to reject the AFCON trophy. I'm officially rejecting it and hope my teammates do the same. We had a chance but failed to win," Hakimi said, while acknowledging Senegal as deserving champions. "That's football; sometimes you win and lose. Senegal beat us fairly and deserved it. It will be unfair to ruin their joy after the hard work," he added. Hakimi reiterated his respect for CAF's decision but maintained his personal stance. "I respect the decision, but I'm officially rejecting the trophy. I didn't win the 2025 AFCON. Congratulations to Senegal once again. (Niebem 1)".

By: Samuel Yeppez

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